

4. Focus on large fixed costs, not small discretionary ones

Many Americans do not earn enough money, and therefore cannot save enough. More than a few will be in trouble come retirement.

Here is where the coffee nonsense gets called out for the bullshit it really is: Prior to the pandemic, wages were flat for three decades; economic mobility was near all-time lows. Healthcare costs keep going up; college has become an economic hardship for many. These are significant issues to most Americans; a \$5 cup of coffee is not.

The problem with your fixed costs is that they are, well, *fixed*. They are often impossible to cut back on. Housing, healthcare, and education are all expensive; coffee, even good coffee, is not. (The same goes for avocado toast.) Please excuse my lack of enthusiasm for fretting over \$5 lattes while we ignore 30-plus years of limited real wage gains for so many people.^{[450](#)}

5. Mental bandwidth

Regardless of your view of the Stanford marshmallow experiment and delayed gratification, there is validity to the claim that willpower is finite.^{[451](#)} All of us have more important issues to exhaust our willpower on than this.

There are much bigger economic issues in everyone's life. Any of these are far larger and more consequential than modest spending. All of us have better things to worry about than denying ourselves the occasional cup of fresh, hot java.

Go enjoy a \$5 latte. While you sip that warm, delicious brew and enjoy its health benefits, ponder the enormous challenges facing millennials, future retirees, boomers—anyone who is not fortunate enough to find themselves in the top third of the American economic strata. It's obvious that penny-wise, pound-foolish solutions miss the bigger picture.
